

The Testimony of Truth

Codex Reference: IX,3

Translated by: Birger A. Pearson and Søren Giversen

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Editor's Introduction

Introduced by Birger A. Pearson

Translated by Søren Giversen and Birger A. Pearson

This tractate is unfortunately poorly preserved, owing to the fragmentary condition of the manuscript. Almost half of the text is lost. Even so, enough material is extant or recoverable to enable us to gain a rather good picture of the tractate's content.

It is possible that a title was originally appended to the tractate at the end (as is the case with 21 of the other tractates in the Nag Hammadi corpus); if so, it would have been part of the last inscribed folio of the codex, which is now lost (pp. 75-76). The title now in universal use has been editorially assigned on the basis of content ("word of truth," 31,8; "true testimony," 45,1), and underscores the author's concern to establish "true" faith and praxis while also exposing the false claims of "heretical" opponents.

Indeed, one of the most interesting features of this tractate is that we see in it the other side of the theological arguments we know so well from the ecclesiastical heresiologists. The author is a Christian Gnostic polemicist, with a strict encratic world view and lifestyle. His chief opponents are catholic Christians of the ecclesiastical establishment. Surprisingly, our gnostic author does not spare fellow Gnostics similar polemical treatment, i.e., Gnostics whose lifestyle and ritual practice differ from his own.

The tractate consists of two main parts. The first is a well-constructed homily on truth versus falsehood, addressed to fellow members of a Christian Gnostic community (29,6-45,6). Its purpose is to bolster the convictions of the author's fellow Gnostics and to warn them against the errors of (catholic) Christian opponents. The second part (45,6-end) consists of miscellaneous additions, including elaborations of themes already sounded in the homily itself. It is in this section that the polemics against other Gnostics occur.

I.

The homily opens with an exordium in which the author appeals to those endowed with spiritual hearing. An attack is then launched against the Law, which for the author is summed up in the command to procreate. The polemics continue with attacks on those who espouse martyrdom in the belief that there will be a "carnal resurrection" (31,22-38,27). Sexual "defilement" (39,5), i.e., marriage and procreation, is vigorously criticized (38,27-41,4), with Jesus' virgin birth used as a sign that Christians should lead a virginal life (40,5-7). The capstone of the homily as a description of the career of the archetypical Gnostic: his renunciation of the world and his reintegration into the realm of imperishability (41,4-44,30). A peroration sums up the "true testimony": self-knowledge is knowledge of God and leads to the "crown unfading" (44,30-45,6).

II.

The appended miscellanea occur in a portion of Codex IX which has sustained considerable damage and loss. It is nevertheless clear that the polemical tone sounded in the homily consists of a gnostic midrash on the serpent of Genesis 3 (45,23-49,10). It retells the paradise story in such a way as to portray the serpent as the revealer of life and knowledge, and God (the Creator) as a malevolent and ignorant demon. This material is probably based on a previously existing source, to which the author of *Testim. Truth* has added some editorial touches, including an allegorical interpretation of the serpent as a symbol of Christ (49,7).

Another interesting section, unfortunately very fragmentary, consists of polemics against the tenets of such other Gnostics as Valentinus (56,2-5), Basilides and his son Isidore (57,6-8), and the Simonians (58,2-3). It is presumably on the basis of their ethical and ritual practices that those teachers and groups are regarded by the author of *Testim. Truth* as heretics. For example, the Valentinians are criticized for their use of the sacrament of baptism (55,7-9); water baptism is consistently condemned in *Testim. Truth* (69,7-24; cf. 30,18-30). The Simonians are criticized for marrying and begetting children (58,2-4), a criticism that would extend to the Valentinians and Basilidians as well.

In short, from beginning to end, our tractate is filled with the polemics of a teacher who earnestly believed that his version of Christian faith and praxis was the only true one, a pamphleteer whose hatred of “heresy” was the match of that of an Irenaeus, a Hippolytus, or a Tertullian. Indeed, our author can be regarded as a mirror-image of the great heresiologists of the Church, representing the other side of the argument.

Who was this man? From what can be gathered from the tractate itself, he was probably an Alexandrian whose Gnostic Christianity was heavily influenced by other Alexandrian gnostic traditions, especially Valentinianism. Yet he rejected certain features of Valentinian doctrine and practice. As it happens, Clement of Alexandria has provided us with information about a gnostic teacher who fits the situation of our author very well: Julius Cassianus. This man had “departed from the school of Valentinus” (*Strom.* III.93) and espoused a strict encratism, condemning marriage and sexual intercourse. Julius Cassianus, of all the heretics known to us by name from ancient sources, is the most likely candidate for the authorship of *Testim. Truth*.

Even if Julius Cassianus is not its author, *Testim. Truth* is most plausibly to be situated in Alexandria and dated to the end of the second century or the beginning of the third.